

Harbor Point Logistics Incident Report: Ammonia Release at Pier 9 Cold Storage Facility

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Executive Summary

This incident report documents the ammonia release that occurred at the Pier 9 Cold Storage Facility of Harbor Point Logistics on 14 January 2026, the response to it, the causes identified by the investigation team and the actions required to prevent a recurrence.

At approximately 04:31 on 14 January 2026 a valve on one of the evaporators in the loading corridor failed and released ammonia gas. The facility was evacuated, the ammonia plant was isolated and the fire department declared the area safe at 07:50. No employee or contractor required hospital treatment, although three employees were assessed for eye irritation. In the days after the event initial estimates of product loss were around \$420,000; the final figure after inspection is given in the Financial Impact section.

The investigation identified four findings and makes three recommendations. The General Manager of the facility has accepted all three recommendations.

Background

The Pier 9 Cold Storage Facility is a 210,000 square foot refrigerated warehouse facility on the company's waterfront site, holding frozen seafood and produce for import customers. The facility operates around the clock with a night shift of 22 staff.

Refrigeration is provided by an anhydrous ammonia plant that is supervised by the Refrigeration Control System, a control and alarm system installed in 2017. The system monitors suction pressure, discharge pressure and ammonia detectors in each room and corridor, and raises alarms to the operator console in the plant room.

Outbound trucking from the facility is performed by Cardinal Fleet Services, a contracted carrier and vendor whose drivers wait at the dock doors during loading. On the night of the incident two of its drivers were on site.

The investigation team consisted of the corporate safety manager, the refrigeration engineer and an independent ammonia specialist. The team interviewed 14 people, reviewed alarm logs and control system trends, and examined the failed valve.

Findings

Finding 1: A corroded valve on the number 3 evaporator released ammonia into the loading corridor for approximately 26 minutes before it was isolated. Severity: High, and the incident would have been rated Critical had the release reached the occupied packing hall. The valve body showed external corrosion consistent with repeated exposure to wash-down water. The corridor detector reached its high alarm threshold within two minutes of the release, but manual isolation required an operator in a respirator to reach the plant room.

Finding 2: The Refrigeration Control System raised a low-pressure alarm at 04:12 but the alarm was acknowledged by the night operator without investigation. Severity: High. The low-pressure alarm was the first indication that ammonia was escaping. The operator stated that low-pressure alarms occur several times a week during defrost cycles and are routinely cleared. The control system does not require a reason to be entered when an alarm is cleared.

Finding 3: Two Cardinal Fleet Services drivers waiting at dock doors 5 and 6 were not included in the evacuation head count. Severity: Medium. The drivers left the building with the loading crew but were not on the head count sheet because the sheet lists only employees. Their absence from the count was noticed by the fire department incident commander, who delayed the all-clear by roughly twenty minutes while the yard was searched.

Finding 4: Emergency escape respirators at all four muster points were within their inspection dates and functioned correctly. Severity: Low. Nine respirators were used during the evacuation and all were later inspected without defect. The team notes this as a control that worked as intended.

Recommendations

Recommendation 1: Replace all evaporator valves of the same model at the Pier 9 Cold Storage Facility within 60 days. Priority: High. The failed valve is one of 24 of the same model installed in wash-down areas. Replacement valves should be of a stainless steel type rated for the corridor environment.

Recommendation 2: Require a documented cause investigation before any refrigeration alarm can be cleared in the Refrigeration Control System. Priority: High. The system vendor should be engaged to add a mandatory reason field, and the defrost cycle alarms that cause frequent nuisance alarms should be re-tuned so that genuine alarms are not lost.

Recommendation 3: Add contractor drivers to the evacuation head count procedure and brief Cardinal Fleet Services on the change. Priority: Medium. The gate system already records each driver on site and can print a list for the head count coordinator.

Financial Impact

The product loss from the release, after inspection and condemnation of exposed inventory, is \$482,000. The loss is covered by the company's stock insurance subject to a deductible of \$50,000. Customers have been notified and replacement stock has been sourced.

The valve replacement cost for all 24 evaporator valves of the affected model is estimated at USD 96,000 including labour. The work can be completed during scheduled defrost windows without closing the facility.

Emergency response contractor costs for ventilation, air monitoring and decontamination came to \$37,500. No regulatory penalty has been proposed, although the release was reported to the environmental regulator as required.

Appendix

Appendix A: Timeline. 04:12 low-pressure alarm raised and acknowledged. 04:31 corridor ammonia detector high alarm. 04:33 evacuation alarm sounded. 04:57 plant isolated by operator in respirator. 05:10 fire department on site. 07:50 all clear declared.

Appendix B: Actions and owners. Recommendation 1 is owned by the Facility Engineering Manager with a target date of 15 March 2026. Recommendation 2 is owned by the Refrigeration Engineer with a target date of 30 April 2026. Recommendation 3 is owned by the Safety Coordinator with a target date of 28 February 2026.

Appendix C: Distribution. This report is distributed to the Chief Executive, the Board Safety Committee, the Pier 9 General Manager and the company's insurers.